Mauryas. Its prosperity continued into and beyond Ashoka's time. So, Ashoka's halt there looks very plausible, and his interaction with citizens of substantial means such as Devi's father, a man of commerce ('setthi'), even more so because an important function of the viceroy was to collect revenue. Traders and merchants were important in this scheme of things since they contributed significantly to the coffers of the Mauryan state.

A point about Ashoka's personality also seems worth considering in this context. By the time he was sent to Ujjayini he was a young man of some experience, a prince who had possibly travelled to Taxila and other parts of his father's empire. If later textual recountings of incidents relating to his life had wanted to conjure up a story around the sowing of his wild oats rather than a regular marriage, they did not have to wait till he reached Vidisha. And, in any case, why Vidisha in particular? If the idea was to show him in a romance rather than a relationship more sober, the story could well have been woven around places that figure earlier or later in his life: Pataliputra, the city of his childhood, or Ujjayini, where he was headed. The fleeting and somewhat incidental way in which Vidisha appears renders the accounts of it as the locale for the beginning of Ashoka's relationship with Devi all the more believable.

The same circumstantial logic has to be applied in order to understand whether Devi was a Buddhist. The places associated with her have strong Buddhist connections. Vidisha is universally recognized as the pivot of the monuments of Sanchi. Marshall's opinion was that 'from first to last, the story of Sanchi was intimately bound up with the fortunes of the great city in whose shadow its sangharama grew and flourished and on whose wealth it was mainly dependent for its support.'[30] Again, local traditions link the largest stupa at Ujjayini, the city where Devi is said to have resided, as one that was built for her. The Kanipura stupa, made of large Mauryan bricks at a height of more than 10 metres, is on the northeastern outskirts of present-day Ujjain. It is locally known as the Vaishya Tekri ('Vaishya caste's